



Mauritius

The islands that make up Mauritius lie in the Indian Ocean east of Madagascar. They have enjoyed considerable economic success following recent industrial diversification and expansion.



GEOGRAPHY

The volcanic main island of Mauritius is ringed by coral reefs, and rises from the coast to a fertile central plateau. The outer islands – Rodriguez, the Agalega Islands, and the Cargados Carajos Shoals – lie some 300 miles (500 km) to the north.



CLIMATE

Warm and humid. Tropical storms are frequent December–March, the hottest and wettest months.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most people are descendants of laborers brought over from India in the 19th century. A small minority of French descent form the wealthiest group. Creoles (descendants of African slaves) complain of discrimination. Literacy is high. Health care is free. Criminal offenses are usually traffic-related; little crime on outer islands.



THE ECONOMY

Clothing manufacture, tourism, and sugar. Loss of preferential trade terms for sugar and textiles. Offshore financial center. New outsourcing and ICT industries. Most food is imported.

INSIGHT: *The islands form part of the Mascarene Archipelago – once a land bridge between Asia and Africa*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Mauritius

DATE OF FORMATION: 1968

CAPITAL: Port Louis

POPULATION: 1.29 million

TOTAL AREA: 718 sq. miles (1860 sq. km)

DENSITY: 1794 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: French Creole, Hindi, Urdu,

Tamil, Chinese, English*, French

RELIGIONS: Hindu 52%, Catholic 26%, Muslim 17%, other 3%, Protestant 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Indo-Mauritian 68%, Creole 27%, other 5%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Mauritian rupee = 100 cents